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Therefore the total energy of the satellite is

$$E = \frac{1}{2}\frac{GM_E M_s}{(R_E + h)} - \frac{GM_s M_E}{(R_E + h)}$$

$$E = -\frac{GM_s M_E}{2(R_E + h)} \qquad (6.66)$$

The negative sign in the total energy implies that the satellite is bound to the Earth and it cannot escape from the Earth.

As h approaches ∞, the total energy tends to zero. Its physical meaning is that the satellite is completely free from the influence of Earth's gravity and is not bound to Earth at large distances.

EXAMPLE 6.10

Calculate the energy of the (i) Moon orbiting the Earth and (ii) Earth orbiting the Sun.

Solution

Assuming the orbit of the Moon to be circular, the energy of Moon is given by,

$$E_m = -\frac{GM_E M_m}{2R_m}$$

where M_E is the mass of Earth 6.02×10^{24} kg; M_m is the mass of Moon 7.35×10^{22} kg; and R_m is the distance between the Moon and the center of the Earth $3.84 \times 10^5\, km$

$$G = 6.67 \times 10^{-11}\, \text{N m}^2\, \text{kg}^{-2}.$$

$$E_m = -\frac{6.67 \times 10^{-11} \times 6.02 \times 10^{24} \times 7.35 \times 10^{22}}{2 \times 3.84 \times 10^5 \times 10^3}$$

$$E_m = -38.42 \times 10^{-19} \times 10^{46}$$

$$E_m = -38.42 \times 10^{46}\ Joule$$

The negative energy implies that the Moon is bound to the Earth.

Same method can be used to prove that the energy of the Earth is also negative.

6.4.3 Geo-stationary and polar satellite

The satellites orbiting the Earth have different time periods corresponding to different orbital radii. Can we calculate the orbital radius of a satellite if its time period is 24 hours?

Kepler's third law is used to find the radius of the orbit.

$$T^2 = \frac{4\pi^2}{GM_E}(R_E + h)^3$$

$$(R_E + h)^3 = \frac{GM_E T^2}{4\pi^2}$$

$$R_E + h = \left(\frac{GM_E T^2}{4\pi^2}\right)^{1/3}$$

Substituting for the time period (24 hrs = 86400 seconds), mass, and radius of the Earth, h turns out to be 36,000 km. Such satellites are called "geo-stationary satellites", since they appear to be stationary when seen from Earth.

India uses the INSAT group of satellites that are basically geo-stationary satellites for the purpose of telecommunication. Another type of satellite which is placed at a distance